

The Morning Briefing

POLITICS · JUDICIARY · MIDDLE EAST · VATICAN · WORLD · LONG READS

LEDE — GULF ESCALATION

Iran strikes US base in Kuwait, vessel hit near Hormuz, as Trump warns Tehran of “last opportunity”

Iran's Foreign Ministry flatly denies talks with Washington even as Trump claims a deal is close — and the IDF goes on high alert for wider escalation.

US POLITICS

Senate clears 89-4 cloture vote on stopgap funding bill, punting shutdown fight past the midterms

The Senate voted 89-4 Monday to invoke cloture on the motion to proceed to H.R. 6500, the vehicle for a continuing resolution that would fund the government through December 11. Only Sens. Tim Kaine (D-Va.), Rand Paul (R-Ky.), Bernie Sanders (I-Vt.), and Elizabeth Warren (D-Mass.) voted no. Majority Leader John Thune called it a “strong, bipartisan piece of legislation.”

WHY IT MATTERS

This is a pre-election shutdown-avoidance deal — both parties want the funding fight to happen after, not before, November. The House has already left for August recess and will not take it up until September, so the truce is provisional.

Washington Times — [washingtontimes.com/news/2026/aug/3/senate-advances-government-funding-stopgap-early-effort-head-shutdown](https://www.washingtontimes.com/news/2026/aug/3/senate-advances-government-funding-stopgap-early-effort-head-shutdown)

Trump administration asks Supreme Court to lift block on mail-ballot restrictions ahead of midterms

The administration asked the justices to lift a lower-court order blocking the president's March 2026 executive order restricting mail-in voting. Justice Ketanji Brown Jackson, who handles emergency appeals from the 1st Circuit, ordered the plaintiff states to respond by Monday.

WHY IT MATTERS

A ruling could reshape mail-ballot eligibility rules in multiple states just months before the midterms — timing that makes this as much a political story as a legal one. See Judiciary section.

Votebeat — votebeat.org/national/2026/08/03/trump-supreme-court-mail-ballot-restrictions-executive-order-usps

SCOTUS & THE JUDICIARY

Sotomayor refuses to halt \$656 million judgment against PLO, Palestinian Authority

Justice Sonia Sotomayor declined Monday to halt a \$656 million judgment against the Palestinian Authority and PLO, won by American victims of attacks in Israel under the Anti-Terrorism Act. The order follows a Supreme Court ruling last year that sided with the plaintiffs on personal jurisdiction.

WHY IT MATTERS

This closes off one more avenue for the PA/PLO to escape a years-old judgment, and signals the Court's continued willingness to let US courts reach foreign political entities over terrorism-related claims.

Washington Times — [washingtontimes.com/news/2026/aug/3/supreme-court-wont-halt-656m-judgment-plo-palestinian-authority](https://www.washingtontimes.com/news/2026/aug/3/supreme-court-wont-halt-656m-judgment-plo-palestinian-authority)

Emergency docket, again: mail-ballot case tests justices' own discomfort with the shadow docket

The mail-in voting emergency application working through Justice Jackson's chambers is a judiciary story as much as a political one. Watch for how it's decided and how fast — several justices, including some conservatives, have recently voiced discomfort with deciding major questions on the emergency docket without full briefing or argument.

SCOTUSblog — scotusblog.com

ISRAEL & THE MIDDLE EAST

Iran strikes US base in Kuwait, vessel hit near Strait of Hormuz; Tehran denies talks Trump claims are underway

Iran struck a US air base in Kuwait and a vessel was hit by an unidentified projectile near the Strait of Hormuz overnight, days after Trump warned Tehran this was its “last opportunity to sign an agreement.” Iran's Foreign Ministry spokesman denied any US talks are underway, telling the Wall Street Journal that Iran's negotiators remain in the country except for the foreign minister, who is at a religious site in Iraq.

ANALYTICAL READ

Trump's public claim of imminent talks and Tehran's flat denial cannot both be accurate reporting of the same reality — one side is shaping perception, not describing fact. Iran gains by projecting it has not been talked into concessions; Trump gains by projecting momentum toward a deal ahead of the midterms. Neither claim should be taken at face value.

Jerusalem Post — jpost.com/middle-east/iran-news/article-904491

Board of Peace reaffirms: no IDF withdrawal past Yellow Line until Hamas fully disarms

The Board of Peace — the US-led postwar body whose members include Jared Kushner, Marco Rubio, Steve Witkoff, and World Bank President Ajay Banga — met Netanyahu Monday and reaffirmed that Israeli forces will not withdraw beyond the Yellow Line in Gaza until Hamas

fully decommissions its weapons. Envoy Nikolay Mladenov reportedly pressed Netanyahu privately to halt ongoing strikes, even as the board's public sequencing mirrors Israel's own stated position. Qatar, Egypt, and Turkey condemned the continued strikes as undermining the peace process.

ANALYTICAL READ

A body branded as an international, US-led peace mechanism has adopted the sequencing Israel wanted from the start — disarmament before withdrawal, on Israel's timeline, with no enforceable deadline on the Israeli side. That is a policy choice with a beneficiary, not a neutral technocratic finding. The condemnation from Qatar, Egypt, and Turkey is the more revealing diplomatic signal here. Note: much of the granular sequencing detail traces to officials speaking anonymously to Hebrew and US outlets — treat it as positioning, not settled fact.

Washington Post — [washingtonpost.com/world/2026/08/03/mideast-gaza-disarmament-hamas-netanyahu/](https://www.washingtonpost.com/world/2026/08/03/mideast-gaza-disarmament-hamas-netanyahu/) / **Jerusalem Post** — jpost.com/middle-east/article-904490

Sourcing note: Gulf reporting still moving

Several of this week's Iran/Gulf items — the Hormuz vessel strike, the Kuwait base strike — rely heavily on early wire and UKMTO reporting. Treat casualty and attribution details as provisional until confirmed by multiple independent outlets.

ITALY, ROME & THE VATICAN

At Angelus, Leo XIV appeals directly for Ceuta: “praying...that solutions may be found”

At his August 2 Angelus in St. Peter's Square, Pope Leo XIV addressed the Ceuta migration crisis directly: “*I am following with concern the alarming situation in Ceuta, praying to God that, through the intercession of Our Lady of Africa, solutions may be found to bring peace, stability and justice.*” He also renewed his appeal that “wars may cease throughout the world” and called for diplomatic solutions, remembering victims of hostilities, “especially children, the elderly and the sick.”

The same address recalled the Pardon of Assisi, the plenary indulgence Saint Francis obtained from Pope Honorius III in 1216 after a vision of Christ and the Virgin Mary surrounded by angels — a granular piece of thirteenth-century canonical history the Pope invoked to frame his present call to mercy.

WHY IT MATTERS

Leo XIV consistently reaches for concrete historical and canonical precedent rather than generic sentiment when he wants a point to land with Catholics.

Vatican.va — [vatican.va/content/leo-xiv/en/angelus/2026/documents/20260802-angelus.html](https://www.vatican.va/content/leo-xiv/en/angelus/2026/documents/20260802-angelus.html)

Pope's August intention: “evangelization in the city” — a full public calendar after July's rest

Leo XIV's prayer intention for August, released by the Vatican's prayer network, asks Catholics to pray “for evangelization in the city,” specifically for the millions who live in dense urban settings and are searching for meaning. He is keeping a full public calendar this month after resting in July at Castel Gandolfo: weekly Wednesday general audiences resume, five Sunday Angelus addresses are scheduled, and he will celebrate Mass for the Transfiguration (Aug. 6) and the Assumption of Mary (Aug. 15). On August 22 he travels to the Republic of San Marino for a pastoral visit, then to Rimini to celebrate Mass for participants in the 47th Meeting for Friendship Among Peoples.

America Magazine — [americamagazine.org/news/2026/07/30/pope-leo-public-masses-audiences-august](https://www.americamagazine.org/news/2026/07/30/pope-leo-public-masses-audiences-august)

WORLD NEWS

Ceuta: largest single migration surge ever recorded on EU soil, 72 dead, Morocco accused of retaliation

Spain's North African enclave of Ceuta is facing the largest single surge of irregular migration ever recorded on EU territory: an estimated 60,000 people crossed from Morocco into a territory with a population of 84,000 over a span of days, many swimming the border using wetsuits and inflatables. At least 72 people have died, mostly by drowning or in a crush at the Tarajal breakwater. The surge is widely read as Moroccan retaliation for Spain's hosting of a Western Sahara independence leader, after Rabat

abruptly loosened border enforcement. Italian PM Giorgia Meloni called for Spain to be suspended from Schengen; the EU has called an emergency meeting.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is the story behind the Pope's Ceuta appeal above, and it is a live test of whether the EU's border and asylum framework can survive a state actor using migration as coercive leverage against a member state.

Al Jazeera — [aljazeera.com/news/2026/8/2/why-has-the-eu-called-an-emergency-meeting-on-spain-migrants-surge](https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2026/8/2/why-has-the-eu-called-an-emergency-meeting-on-spain-migrants-surge) / **CNN** — [cnn.com/2026/08/01/europe/spain-morocco-migrants-intl](https://www.cnn.com/2026/08/01/europe/spain-morocco-migrants-intl)

RESEARCH & LONG READS

Islamic theology, critical angle: van Putten on the textual history of the Quran

Marijn van Putten, "Textual Criticism of the Quran," in *The Comparative Textual Criticism of Religious Scriptures* (Brill, 2024), open access via Leiden University. A working Quranic-studies scholar lays out the historical-critical method applied to the Quran: oral recitation traditions with real multiformity, the later push toward a single standardized text, and manuscript evidence that complicates the traditional account of an immediately fixed, divinely preserved text. A rigorous, non-polemical entry point into the textual-criticism case against the traditional Islamic account of the Quran's transmission — the same method Biblical scholars apply to scripture, applied consistently.

WHY NOW

With Iran and the Gulf back in the headlines, this is a good week to read serious scholarship on Islamic textual history rather than only geopolitics.

Leiden University — scholarlypublications.universiteitleiden.nl/handle/1887/3761723

The American right: Laura Field on the intellectuals behind the New Right

Oxford Political Review's interview with Laura Field on her book *Furious Minds: The Making of the New Right* (Princeton University Press, 2025). Field traces the MAGA New Right from Straussian academic circles and paleoconservatism through to figures like Patrick Deneen ("Machiavellian means to achieve Aristotelian ends") and Harvard's Adrian Vermeule, whose Catholic integralism argues the state should be subordinated to the Church's authority on the common good. She argues the movement has captured institutions like the Heritage Foundation while remaining, by her account, intellectually uneven and shot through with an authoritarian strain.

WHY NOW

Directly relevant to today's midterm-positioning maneuvering in Congress, and Vermeule's integralism is a live argument inside Catholic political thought worth knowing on its own terms, whether or not you find it persuasive.

Oxford Political Review — [oxfordpoliticalreview.com/2026/03/31/the-right-wing-intellectuals-who-keep-winning](https://www.oxfordpoliticalreview.com/2026/03/31/the-right-wing-intellectuals-who-keep-winning)